

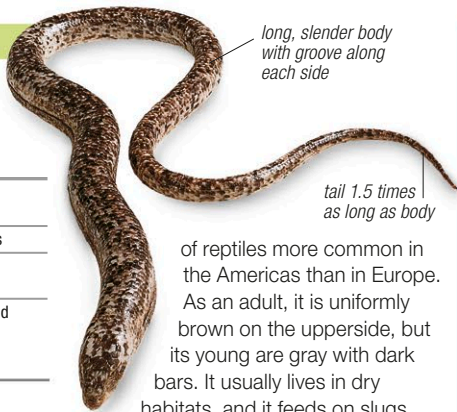
Pseudopus apodus

European glass lizard



Location S.E. Europe, W. Asia

Length 3¼–4 ft (1–1.2 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial/Burrowing
Status Not evaluated



of reptiles more common in the Americas than in Europe. As an adult, it is uniformly brown on the upperside, but its young are gray with dark bars. It usually lives in dry habitats, and it feeds on slugs, snails, and invertebrates. If caught, it may discard its tail or smear its captor with feces. Females lay 8–10 eggs, and bury them in damp sand or soil.



With a length exceeding that of many snakes, this legless lizard is the largest member of the family Anguidae—a group

Ophisaurus ventralis

Eastern glass lizard



Location S.E. USA

Length 18–43 in (45–108 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial/Burrowing
Status Least concern



This legless lizard is one of 4 closely related species found in North America. Brown with black flanks, it lives mainly in damp meadows—usually on the surface, unlike some of its relatives, which spend most of

their time underground. Its tail is over twice as long as the rest of its body, and is easily shed. Active early in the morning and after rain, the eastern glass lizard feeds on slugs, snails, insects, and small vertebrates. The female lays 8–17 eggs in damp soil, and guards them until they hatch.

Anniella geronimensis

Baja California legless lizard

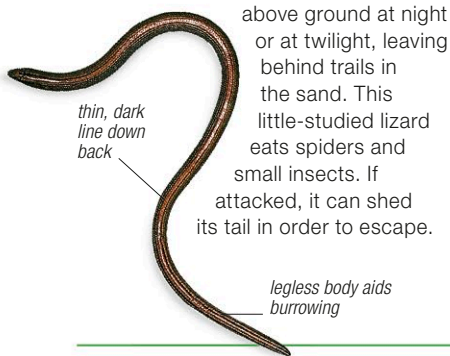


Location Mexico (Baja California)

Length 4–6 in (10–15 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Endangered



The Baja California legless lizard is a small, slender species with a silvery to light brown body. It does not create permanent burrows, but “swims” through loose sand just below the surface, especially around the base of low-growing shrubs. It may come



above ground at night or at twilight, leaving behind trails in the sand. This little-studied lizard eats spiders and small insects. If attacked, it can shed its tail in order to escape.

Heloderma suspectum

Gila monster



Location S.W. USA, N. Mexico

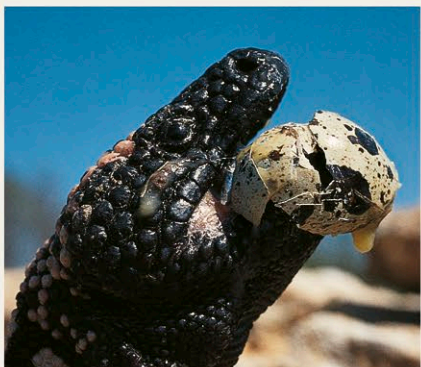
Length 14–20 in (35–50 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial/Burrowing
Status Near threatened



The Gila monster is one of North America’s most distinctive reptiles, and one of only 2 dangerously venomous lizards in the world. Its bulky body is marked with orange, pink, or yellow, contrasting with bands of black warning potential aggressors that it has a toxic bite. Gila monsters live in semidesert or scrub with rocky outcrops, in places where there is ready access to moisture. Compared to most other lizards, they are slow-moving, hunting by day in the spring but at dusk or after dark during the summer heat. The tail stores fat in the same way as a camel’s hump; it shrinks when food is hard to find, especially in cold weather when the Gila monster hibernates. Females lay their eggs in late summer, burying clutches of up to 8 in burrows scooped out of damp sand.

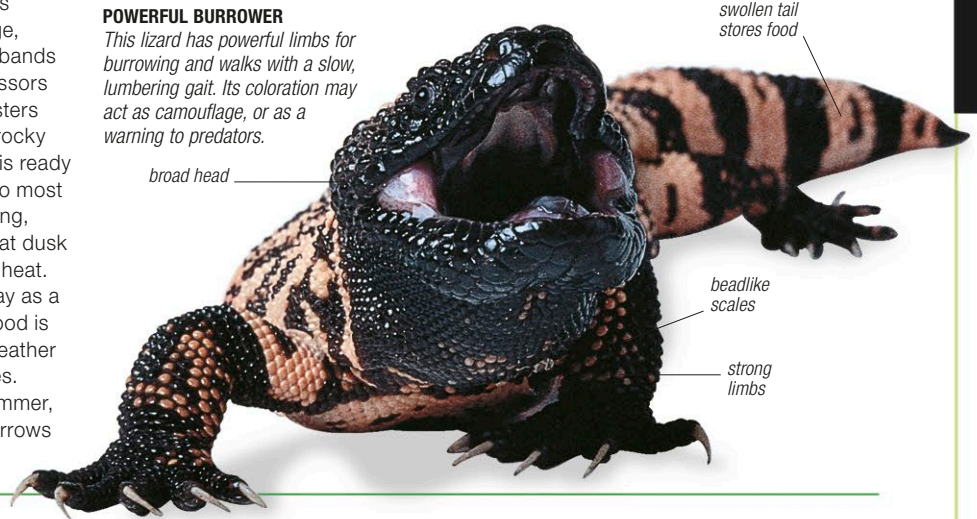
FEEDING HABITS

The Gila monster feeds on small mammals and the eggs of quails, doves, and reptiles. It hunts by smell and also “tastes” its surroundings with its tongue. Venom is produced in glands in the lower jaw, not the upper jaw as in snakes. The lizard bites fiercely with its sharp teeth and holds onto its victim while the poison enters the wound. The bite, although painful, is not fatal to adult humans.



POWERFUL BURROWER

This lizard has powerful limbs for burrowing and walks with a slow, lumbering gait. Its coloration may act as camouflage, or as a warning to predators.



Heloderma horridum

Mexican beaded lizard



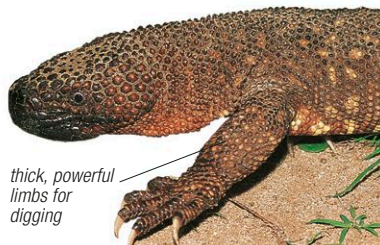
Location W. Mexico

Length 28–39 in (70–100 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial/Burrowing
Status Least concern



A close relative of the Gila monster (see above), the Mexican beaded lizard, too, is venomous, but its colors are more subdued. It is often dark brown with paler blotches, but in

the south of its range it is entirely black. This lizard hides in burrows, emerging to forage for birds, especially fledglings, as well as eggs, and small mammals. It bites and injects venom into its prey with the sharp, grooved teeth in its lower jaw. Although painful, its bite is not often fatal to humans. Females lay 4–10 large, elongated eggs in burrows.



Lanthanotus borneensis

Borneo earless lizard



Location S.E. Asia

Length 16–18 in (40–45 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Burrowing/Semiaquatic
Status Not evaluated



This efficient swimmer inhabits streamside burrows, which may become flooded. Its short limbs and blunt snout are adaptations for burrowing, while the transparent eyelids and nostrils that can be closed by valves are adapted for living in water.

Being nocturnal and secretive, it is hardly ever seen. Only about 100 specimens have been collected since it was first described in 1878 and it remains poorly known. Once believed to be related to the heloderms (the Gila monster, above, and the Mexican beaded lizard, left) and, later, the monitors (see p.430), it is now thought not to have any living close relatives.

